

Ethics Case Studies Bank

50+ Cases with Solved Framework

UPSC Mains General Studies Paper 4 — Ethics, Integrity & Aptitude

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1. The Universal Framework for Solving Case Studies

The UPSC Ethics paper rewards a structured, reasoned approach to case studies. Adopt this six-step framework for every case:

Framework for Any Case Study (Memorise This)

1. **Identify:** List key ethical issues and the moral dilemma
2. **Stakeholders:** List all affected parties with their interests
3. **Options:** Generate 3-4 possible courses of action
4. **Analyse:** Evaluate each option against ethical frameworks (Deontology, Utilitarianism, Virtue Ethics)
5. **Recommend:** Choose the best option with justification
6. **Implement:** Describe how to execute the chosen action

Common Ethical Frameworks Reference

Framework	Core Idea	When to Apply
Deontology (Kant)	Duty-based; follow universal moral rules regardless of consequences	Where rights, duties, and rules are paramount — never lie, never bribe
Utilitarianism (Mill/Bentham)	Greatest good for the greatest number; consequences matter	Policy decisions, resource allocation, development vs displacement dilemmas
Virtue Ethics (Aristotle)	Focus on character; what would a virtuous person do?	When role models, integrity, and personal values are at stake
Rawls' Justice Theory	Justice as fairness; protect the most vulnerable	Social justice, caste/gender discrimination, inequality
Gandhian Ethics	Means are as important as ends; non-violence; Sarvodaya	Social movements, civil disobedience, inclusive development

2. Bribery & Corruption (8 Cases)

Case 1: The Tender Supervising Officer

Scenario: You are a Supervising Officer in the Public Works Department. A contractor offers you Rs 10 lakh to certify a substandard road as satisfactory. The road has potholes and poor sub-base preparation. The contractor says everyone in the department takes such kickbacks. Your project head has hinted that you should cooperate.

Ethical Issues: Corruption, public safety breach, professional integrity vs peer pressure, duty to the public.

Stakeholders: You (officer), contractor, project head, public road users, department reputation, government exchequer.

Options: (a) Accept the bribe and certify the road. (b) Refuse the bribe, report to vigilance. (c) Refuse but remain silent. (d) Convince the contractor to fix quality while reporting to senior officials anonymously.

Recommended Action: Option (b) — Refuse and report. Deontological ethics demands upholding duty as a civil servant. The harm to public safety outweighs any short-term career risk. File a written complaint to the Chief Engineer and simultaneously approach the vigilance department. The 'everyone does it' argument is a classic rationalisation of corruption.

Framework: Deontology (duty of public servant), Virtue Ethics (integrity, courage).

Case 2: The Medical Superintendent

Scenario: You are the Medical Superintendent of a district hospital. A pharmaceutical company offers you a fully-funded international medical conference in Switzerland, plus a "consulting fee" of Rs 5 lakh, if you prescribe their brand of medicines. The medicines are genuine but 40% more expensive than equivalent generics.

Ethical Issues: Conflict of interest, kickbacks in healthcare, duty to patients, public health impact.

Stakeholders: Patients (primarily poor), hospital, pharmaceutical company, your family, medical profession's reputation.

Options: (a) Accept the offer — it's common practice among doctors. (b)

Reject the offer and report to the Medical Council. (c) Accept but use generic alternatives where possible. (d) Use the opportunity to negotiate lower prices for the hospital.

Recommended Action: Option (b) — Reject and report. The Hippocratic Oath requires putting patient welfare above personal gain. The 40% price differential places an unfair burden on poor patients. Utilitarian calculus proves that rejection prevents harm to thousands of patients.

Framework: Hippocratic Oath, Deontology, Fiduciary duty.

Case 3: The Tax Officer's Dilemma

Scenario: As an Income Tax Officer, you discover that a prominent politician has undisclosed foreign assets worth Rs 50 crore. The politician's aide meets you and offers Rs 2 crore to "lose" the file. He reminds you that the politician has influence over your next posting — a comfortable urban post vs a hardship rural posting.

Ethical Issues: Bribery, tax evasion, criminal conspiracy, abuse of political power.

Stakeholders: You, politician, taxpayer community, government revenue, Income Tax Department.

Options: (a) Accept the bribe and destroy evidence. (b) Reject, proceed with assessment and file prosecution complaint. (c) Transfer the case to another officer. (d) Leak the information to media.

Recommended Action: Option (b). The Income Tax Act imposes a statutory duty to assess and collect due taxes. Accepting a bribe to abet tax evasion is criminal conspiracy under the Prevention of Corruption Act. Document all interactions (covert recording if legally permissible) to protect yourself against the politician's influence. Approach the CBDT with full evidence.

Framework: Deontology (statutory duty), Rule of Law, Constitutional oath.

Case 4: The Ration Shop Dealer

Scenario: As District Food Supply Officer, you discover massive irregularities in PDS — rations are being sold in the open market by a dealer, while the below-poverty-line cardholders receive half their entitled quota. The dealer is a former MLA's relative. Your subordinate tells you to ignore it as "every district has this."

Ethical Issues: Corruption in PDS, food security violation, rights of the poor, nexus with political power.

Stakeholders: BPL families, PDS dealer, political patron, your subordinates, Food Corporation of India, state government.

Options: (a) Issue a warning to the dealer. (b) Suspend the dealer's license and file FIR. (c) Report through proper channel and await orders. (d) Conduct a surprise inspection and gather solid evidence before acting.

Recommended Action: Option (d) followed by (b). Conduct a joint surprise inspection with vigilance wing. Gather documentary evidence of diversion. Suspend the license immediately under the Essential Commodities Act. File an FIR. The Right to Food is a legal entitlement — its violation is a criminal offense.

Framework: Right to Food, Social Justice, Rawls (protect the most vulnerable), Utilitarianism.

Case 5: The Transfer Racket

Scenario: You are an honest officer transferred to a remote tribal district after refusing to pay a bribe to the Minister's secretary for a good posting. On day one, your subordinates inform you that postings in the tribal development department involve 20% kickbacks from all development scheme allocations. They expect you to maintain the "system."

Ethical Issues: Institutionalised corruption, tribal welfare compromise, retaliation for honesty, administrative pressure.

Stakeholders: You, tribal beneficiaries, corrupt staff, Minister's secretary, state government.

Options: (a) Maintain the system to avoid further trouble. (b) Begin systematic reforms and vigilance investigations. (c) Request transfer again. (d) Go public with evidence.

Recommended Action: Option (b). You have a moral and constitutional duty to ensure development funds reach tribals. Start by building a case against the worst offenders. Use the Tribal Sub-Plan audit trail. Engage with civil society organisations working on tribal rights. Transformational leadership requires enduring short-term hardship for long-term institutional change.

Framework: Virtue Ethics (transformational leadership), Rawls' Justice, Constitutional duty.

Case 6: The Police Inspector's Choice

Scenario: As a Police Inspector, you stop a vehicle at a night checkpoint and find Rs 25 lakh in cash, unaccounted. The driver is a local councillor's personal

assistant. He offers you Rs 2 lakh to let him go, saying the money is for "political work." Your constables look the other way expectantly, expecting their share.

Ethical Issues: Bribery, criminal investigation obstruction, political interference, team management.

Stakeholders: You, constables, councillor, public, state police force reputation.

Options: (a) Accept the bribe and share with constables. (b) Seize the cash, register an offence under CrPC Section 102 and PMLA. (c) Let him go but report to seniors. (d) Seize the cash and transfer it to another team.

Recommended Action: Option (b). Unaccounted cash above Rs 10 lakh requires mandatory reporting. Register FIR under the relevant sections of IPC and Income Tax Act. Your constables' expectations are irrelevant to your legal duty. Explain to them the legal consequences of abetting such an offense.

Framework: Rule of Law, Police duty under CrPC, Deontology.

Case 7: The Scholarship Fraud

Scenario: As the Block Development Officer, you discover that scholarships for SC/ST students have been systematically diverted by the Block Education Officer and three school principals for the past three years. Students have received nothing. The beneficiaries are too scared to complain.

Ethical Issues: Corruption in social welfare schemes, educational rights violation, SC/ST rights, bureaucratic collusion.

Stakeholders: SC/ST students, Block Education Officer, school principals, your responsibility as BDO, state government.

Options: (a) Refer the matter to the District Magistrate. (b) Conduct a detailed inquiry with student testimonies. (c) Initiate recovery proceedings and suspension of guilty officers. (d) Warn the culprits and demand they quietly restore the funds.

Recommended Action: Option (b) + (c). Collect documentary evidence and student affidavits. The SC/ST (Prevention of Atrocities) Act provides for special courts. Initiate departmental proceedings and file a criminal complaint. Ensure proper disbursement to students before the next academic year.

Framework: Social Justice, Constitutional guarantees (Article 46), Rawls, Gandhian (Antyodaya).

Case 8: The NHM Procurement Scam

Scenario: You are posted as Chief Medical Officer and discover that the NHM procurement for medicines was done at 300% of market rates. The suppliers are linked to the Health Minister's office. Your predecessors have all "looked the other way." Patients at the district hospital are dying due to shortage of essential drugs because the inflated procurement used up the budget.

Ethical Issues: Procurement corruption, right to health, loss of life due to systemic corruption, political interference.

Stakeholders: Patients, Minister's office, suppliers, CMO (you), hospital staff, state health department.

Options: (a) Report to the state vigilance commission. (b) Stop payments and initiate re-tendering. (c) Quietly negotiate with suppliers to reduce rates. (d) Approve and ensure medicines reach patients.

Recommended Action: Option (a) + (b). Immediately freeze all payments. Emergency procurement should be done to ensure no further loss of life. Simultaneously file a detailed report to the State Vigilance Commission. The loss of human life due to corruption transforms this from a financial irregularity to a criminal culpability issue.

Framework: Right to Life (Article 21), Deontology, Utilitarianism (maximise lives saved).

3. Conflict of Interest (6 Cases)

Case 9: The City Planner's Dilemma

Scenario: As Municipal Commissioner, your brother-in-law's construction company has bid for a Rs 200 crore smart city project. His bid is technically the best and 5% cheaper than the next bidder. Your wife urges you to approve it, saying your brother-in-law needs the project and the bid is genuinely competitive.

Ethical Issues: Conflict of interest, nepotism, procedural fairness, family pressure vs professional duty.

Stakeholders: You, brother-in-law, wife, other bidders, municipal corporation, city residents.

Options: (a) Approve the bid — it's the cheapest. (b) Recuse yourself and let the next senior officer decide. (c) Disqualify the bid citing conflict of interest rules. (d) Ask your brother-in-law to withdraw voluntarily.

Recommended Action: Option (b). Recusal is the cleanest option. Disclosure of interest is mandatory under conduct rules. Even if the bid is genuinely the best, approval by a related party creates a perception of bias that undermines public trust. Option (d) may also be pursued as a supplementary step.

Framework: Conflict of Interest Rules (Civil Services Conduct Rules), Transparency, Procedural Justice.

Case 10: The PSU Chairman's Son

Scenario: You are Chairman of a public sector bank. Your son, fresh out of business school, has joined a company that is the largest borrower from your bank (Rs 1,000 crore outstanding). Your son has no involvement in the loan accounts, but it's a potential conflict.

Ethical Issues: Conflict of interest, perception of impropriety, fiduciary duty to depositors, regulatory compliance.

Stakeholders: You, your son, your bank, depositors, RBI, the borrowing company.

Options: (a) Do nothing — your son is a junior employee with no influence. (b) Disclose the conflict to the Board and recuse yourself from all decisions regarding that company. (c) Ask your son to quit the job. (d) Transfer the loan

account to another bank.

Recommended Action: Option (b). Full disclosure to the Board and complete recusal from all decisions related to the borrowing company. Documentation of the recusal is essential for RBI compliance. Option (c) is disproportionate unless actual interference is proven.

Framework: Fiduciary duty, Regulatory compliance, Transparency, Virtue Ethics (prudence).

Case 11: The District Magistrate as Land Owner

Scenario: You are District Magistrate in a district where the government plans a highway acquisition. You own 5 acres of agricultural land in the corridor. Land prices are expected to triple. Your family wants you to retain the land and benefit from the appreciation. Acquisition has not been officially notified yet.

Ethical Issues: Insider information, misuse of official position, conflict of interest, personal gain from government decisions.

Stakeholders: You, your family, other land owners, government, affected farmers.

Options: (a) Retain the land — everyone knows about the highway. (b) Sell the land immediately to avoid conflict. (c) Disclose your holdings and transfer the DM role to someone else. (d) Include your land in the acquisition pool like everyone else.

Recommended Action: Option (c) — disclose and recuse. Option (b) — selling now could be seen as profiting from insider knowledge. Option (d) — including your land for acquisition at government rates is the most scrupulous path. The All India Services Conduct Rules explicitly prohibit using official position for personal benefit.

Framework: Civil Services Conduct Rules, Conflict of Interest, Transparency, Good Governance.

Case 12: The Teacher-Turned-Principal

Scenario: As principal of a government school, you must select a contractor for the mid-day meal kitchen. Your wife runs a catering business and is well-qualified. She is upset that you won't even consider her bid, saying other government schools give such contracts to relatives openly.

Ethical Issues: Conflict of interest, nepotism, perception of corruption, family obligations.

Stakeholders: You, wife, students, other caterers, education department.

Options: (a) Give the contract to your wife — she's the most qualified. (b) Recuse yourself and let a committee decide. (c) Disqualify your wife outright. (d) Ask your wife to not apply.

Recommended Action: Option (b). Form a tender committee of three teachers and a parent representative to evaluate all bids transparently. This ensures the best caterer gets the contract while removing any perception of bias.

Framework: Procedural fairness, Conflict of Interest, Collective decision-making.

Case 13: The Loan Officer's Relative

Scenario: As a bank officer in a regional rural bank, your cousin applies for a Mudra loan of Rs 5 lakh to start a tailoring business. Her application is weak — no collateral, no business plan, high debt already. She begs you, saying no other bank will give her a loan and she will lose her house.

Ethical Issues: Conflict of interest, fiduciary responsibility, compassion vs rules, discrimination in lending.

Stakeholders: You, cousin, bank, depositors, other loan applicants.

Options: (a) Sanction the loan despite weak credentials. (b) Reject as per banking norms. (c) Help your cousin prepare a better business plan and apply to a different branch. (d) Sanction but keep the file incomplete.

Recommended Action: Option (c). You cannot sanction a loan to a relative — it violates banking regulations and conflict of interest norms. However, you can guide her to improve her application and submit it to another branch where the decision will be independent. Compassion and rule-following are not mutually exclusive.

Framework: Fiduciary duty, Conflict of Interest Rules, Compassion in administration.

Case 14: The Wildlife Warden's Lodge

Scenario: As District Forest Officer and Wildlife Warden, your spouse runs an eco-lodge inside the tiger reserve — a legal business established before your posting. Tour operators claim they get preferential treatment for safari permits because of your relationship. Your spouse says no favours have been given.

Ethical Issues: Conflict of interest, perception of bias, regulatory neutrality, wildlife conservation integrity.

Stakeholders: You, spouse, tour operators, tourists, forest department, tiger conservation.

Options: (a) Do nothing — no actual favour given. (b) Disclosure to the Chief Wildlife Warden and voluntary recusal from safari permit decisions. (c) Ask spouse to close the lodge. (d) Independent audit of permit allocation.

Recommended Action: Option (b) + (d). Full disclosure and recusal. The perception of bias is itself harmful to the Forest Department's credibility. An independent audit of permit allocation will clear the air. Option (c) is too drastic if the lodge operates legally.

Framework: Transparency, Conflict of Interest, Environmental ethics, Rule of Law.

4. Personal vs Professional Duty (6 Cases)

Case 15: The Mother's Illness

Scenario: You are the District Election Officer for a critical by-election. Your 70-year-old mother is hospitalised with a stroke and is critical. Your presence is required 24/7 at the election control room for the next 10 days. Your brother, a software engineer in Bangalore, says he cannot come due to work. Your mother needs you emotionally.

Ethical Issues: Filial duty vs professional duty, responsibility to family vs responsibility to the electoral process.

Stakeholders: You, mother, brother, Election Commission, constituency voters, your subordinates.

Options: (a) Stay with mother, delegate to Deputy DEO. (b) Stay at work, visit mother nightly. (c) Request the Commission for a replacement. (d) Bring mother to the district guest house with medical care.

Recommended Action: Option (c) is ideal if a replacement is feasible. Option (a) with robust delegation is practical — delegate routine work but stay available for critical decisions. Option (d) is a creative middle path. The key is not to compromise the electoral process while fulfilling filial duty. Option (b) risks burnout and poor performance in both roles.

Framework: Virtue Ethics (balance of virtues), Role ethics, Care ethics.

Case 16: The Daughter's Wedding

Scenario: You are the Chief Electoral Officer during General Elections. Your daughter's wedding is scheduled during the polling phase. The family has been planning for a year, invitations sent, arrangements finalised. Cancelling would cause huge emotional and financial loss. But election duty is paramount.

Ethical Issues: Family duty vs constitutional duty, prior commitment vs current responsibility.

Stakeholders: You, daughter, spouse, Election Commission, political parties, voters.

Options: (a) Take leave for the wedding as planned. (b) Cancel the wedding.

(c) Postpone the wedding. (d) Delegate critical election duties for 2 days.

Recommended Action: Option (c) — postpone the wedding. Election Commission's Model Code of Conduct requires all officers to be available. However, a one-day postponement with family counselling may work. Option (b) is too harsh on the family. The key is transparent communication with the Commission and family to find the least harmful compromise.

Framework: Role ethics, Proportionality, Virtue Ethics (practical wisdom).

Case 17: The Classmate's Request

Scenario: Your batchmate from IAS training is now private secretary to a Minister who has been making controversial statements on minority rights. Your batchmate calls you, saying the Minister is a good person who is being misquoted, and asks you to write an anonymous article defending the Minister in a newspaper where you have contacts. He says it will help his career.

Ethical Issues: Professional integrity, truth vs friendship, anonymous political advocacy, misuse of civil service position.

Stakeholders: You, batchmate, Minister, your service, media, public.

Options: (a) Agree to help a friend. (b) Refuse politely, explaining why it's wrong. (c) Offer to write a factual rebuttal if the Minister issues a corrected statement. (d) Report the request to seniors.

Recommended Action: Option (b). Civil servants must maintain absolute neutrality. Writing anonymous political articles violates the Conduct Rules. Moreover, it compromises the independence and credibility of the civil service. Option (c) is a constructive alternative if the Minister genuinely wants to correct the record.

Framework: Political neutrality, Civil Services Conduct Rules, Deontology (duty to truth).

Case 18: The Family Business

Scenario: Your father runs a mid-sized civil contracting company. After your posting as Executive Engineer in the same district, your father's company starts winning tenders at a much higher rate. You have no involvement in the tendering process, but your subordinates might be favouring your father's company because of who you are.

Ethical Issues: Unintentional nepotism, systemic conflict of interest, responsibility for subordinates' actions.

Stakeholders: You, father, other contractors, your department, state

government.

Options: (a) Do nothing — you are not involved. (b) Request transfer to another district. (c) Issue a written order barring your father's company from all contracts in your jurisdiction. (d) Investigate if your father is actually being favoured.

Recommended Action: Option (c). The perception of favouritism is damaging enough to warrant action. A written bar on the company from contracts under your jurisdiction is the most ethical path. This protects the department's integrity and your own reputation. Option (b) is a partial solution — the problem may recur elsewhere.

Framework: Transparency, Conflict of Interest, Virtue Ethics (integrity), Civil Services Conduct Rules.

Case 19: The Sick Child

Scenario: You are a key negotiator for India at the COP climate summit. On day 2, you receive news that your child has been hospitalised with Dengue. Your spouse is with the child, but the doctors say the situation is serious. Your role at COP is critical for India's position on climate finance. The summit is 10 days long.

Ethical Issues: Parental duty vs national duty, delegation vs personal presence at critical negotiations.

Stakeholders: You, child, spouse, Indian government, climate negotiations, global community.

Options: (a) Return immediately. (b) Stay and complete the negotiations. (c) Delegate to deputy and return, staying available virtually. (d) Request the government to send a replacement.

Recommended Action: Option (c). Modern technology allows virtual participation. A deputy can handle routine sessions while you remain available for critical votes. The child's health is paramount, but complete abandonment of national duty is also problematic. Balanced approach with transparent communication with both family and Ministry.

Framework: Care ethics, Virtue Ethics (practical wisdom), Proportionality.

Case 20: The Retired Servant's Plea

Scenario: Your domestic servant of 20 years, who raised you, is now old and needs a permanent job for her son. She begs you to use your influence as a senior IAS officer to get her son a government job. She says she never asked

for anything in 20 years. You know you cannot use influence for government jobs. But you feel intense moral obligation.

Ethical Issues: Personal gratitude vs rule of law, special obligation to those who served us.

Stakeholders: You, servant, servant's son, other job applicants, your service.

Options: (a) Use influence to get the son a job. (b) Refuse and explain the rules honestly. (c) Help the son with skill training and private sector placement. (d) Give money instead.

Recommended Action: Option (c). You cannot misuse your position. But you can use your network to get the son vocational training (free/ subsidised) and help him apply for private sector jobs where merit is the criterion. Personal gratitude must be expressed within the boundaries of public ethics. Option (d) is a supplement, not a substitute.

Framework: Rule of Law, Gratitude ethics (within bounds), Virtue Ethics (compassion with integrity).

5. Land Acquisition & Displacement (4 Cases)

Case 21: The Railway Project

Scenario: A new railway line will pass through a tribal village. 50 families will be displaced. The Railways offers cash compensation as per the RFCTLARR Act 2013. The tribals refuse compensation, saying the land is their deity's land and their identity. They vow to resist physically. You are the District Magistrate.

Ethical Issues: Development vs cultural rights, tribal land rights, displacement trauma, cultural identity vs national interest.

Stakeholders: Tribal families, Railways, state government, forest department, you.

Options: (a) Enforce acquisition through police. (b) Abandon the project alignment. (c) Negotiate for modified alignment with reduced impact. (d) Offer enhanced rehabilitation package including community facilities.

Recommended Action: Option (c) — explore alternative alignment that minimises displacement. If unavoidable, option (d) with community consent. FRA 2006 and PESA require free prior informed consent of tribal communities. Cash compensation for sacred land is inadequate — community rehabilitation with cultural preservation is needed.

Framework: Rawls (protect vulnerable), FRA 2006, PESA, Participatory justice.

Case 22: The SEZ Land Grab

Scenario: As a District Collector, you receive a proposal to acquire 5,000 acres of fertile multi-cropped land for a new SEZ. The company promises 50,000 jobs. However, 5,000 farmers will lose their land. Most are small and marginal farmers. Farmers' groups protest. The Chief Minister's office pushes for speedy acquisition.

Ethical Issues: Food security vs industrialisation, livelihoods vs jobs, political pressure vs due process.

Stakeholders: Small farmers, company, state government, landless labourers,

future job seekers.

Options: (a) Process acquisition as directed. (b) Recommend using waste/barren land instead. (c) Facilitate direct purchase at market rates. (d) Conduct proper social impact assessment and public hearings.

Recommended Action: Option (b) + (d). The RFCTLARR Act 2013 mandates Social Impact Assessment for multi-crop land acquisition. Undertake SIA properly. Recommend to government that only wasteland/barren land be used — India has 55 lakh hectares of wasteland. If acquisition must proceed, ensure employment for at least one family member per displaced family.

Framework: RFCTLARR Act 2013, Food Security, Rawls' Justice, Sustainable Development.

Case 23: The Reluctant Widow

Scenario: An elderly widow, sole owner of a 2-acre plot, refuses to sell for a national highway project. The compensation is adequate (Rs 50 lakh per acre). Her son (who lives in the city) pressures her to accept. She says the land holds memories of her husband and she wants to die on her land. All other 200 families have agreed.

Ethical Issues: Individual rights vs collective good, emotional attachment vs material compensation, family pressure.

Stakeholders: Widow, son, highway authority, other 200 families, you (DM).

Options: (a) Acquire the land under urgency clause. (b) Redesign the highway to bypass her plot. (c) Offer enhanced compensation or alternative land. (d) Ask the son to convince her with more time.

Recommended Action: Option (b) if technically feasible — a small deviation to respect her wish. If not, option (c) — offer an equivalent plot nearby with a house constructed, preserving her connection to the area. Option (d) — give her time, possibly months, with counselling. The cost of delay is worth respecting an elderly person's profound emotional connection.

Framework: Care ethics, Dignity of the individual, Proportionality, Virtue Ethics (compassion).

Case 24: The Industrial Corridor

Scenario: An industrial corridor project requires acquisition of 10,000 acres across 50 villages. The state government promises "land-for-jobs" — one job per family. Two years after acquisition, only 5% of families have received jobs.

The rest are landless and jobless. You are the new Divisional Commissioner. Displaced families protest at your office daily.

Ethical Issues: Broken promises, rehabilitation failure, loss of livelihood, government accountability.

Stakeholders: Displaced families, industries (yet to set up), state government, you.

Options: (a) Explain that jobs will come when industries start. (b) Escalate to Chief Secretary with a comprehensive rehabilitation plan. (c) Use district administration funds for immediate livelihood support. (d) Mediate with industries to expedite recruitment.

Recommended Action: Option (b) + (c) + (d) in combination. The state has a moral and legal obligation under the RFCTLARR Act. Immediate crisis relief (food, cash transfers) from district contingency funds. Medium-term skill training and livelihood generation programmes. Long-term follow-up with industries. Your role is to hold the state accountable to its promise.

Framework: Accountability, Right to Livelihood (Article 21), Distributive Justice, Good Governance.

6. Environment vs Development (4 Cases)

Case 25: The River Sand Mining

Scenario: As District Magistrate, you receive a scientific report that illegal sand mining in the river is causing severe ecological damage — riverbed deepening, groundwater depletion, bridge foundation exposure. Local builders and the construction industry pressure you to allow mining, saying sand shortage will stop construction and cause unemployment. Mining mafia is active.

Ethical Issues: Environmental degradation vs economic activity, rule of law vs pressure groups, corruption nexus.

Stakeholders: River ecosystem, builders, construction workers, local communities, mining mafia, you.

Options: (a) Crack down on illegal mining with police force. (b) Regulate with strict environmental safeguards and alternative sites. (c) Allow status quo as it supports employment. (d) Promote river-sand alternatives like M-sand.

Recommended Action: Option (a) + (b) + (d). Crush illegal mining through surprise raids and prosecution under the Mines & Minerals Act and Environment Protection Act. Simultaneously identify alternative sand reaches and promote manufactured sand (M-sand). Regulate legal mining with GPS tracking of trucks to prevent leakage into illegal channels.

Framework: Sustainable Development, Polluter Pays Principle, Rule of Law, Precautionary Principle.

Case 26: The Coal Block Dilemma

Scenario: A coal block in a dense forest has been allocated to a state PSU for a power plant. It will displace 200 tribal families and requires felling of 5,000 trees. The Forest Department says forest clearance will take time. The state government says the power plant is critical for the state's energy needs and will create 2,000 direct and 5,000 indirect jobs.

Ethical Issues: Energy security vs forest conservation, tribal rights, climate change implications.

Stakeholders: Tribal families, forest ecosystem, state PSU, future employees, electricity consumers.

Options: (a) Clear the forest for development. (b) Reject the project entirely. (c) Ensure strict compliance with Forest Rights Act and Wildlife Clearance. (d) Explore alternative coal blocks outside forests.

Recommended Action: Option (c) + (d). The Forest Conservation Act and FRA 2006 require Free Prior Informed Consent (FPIC) of tribal communities and compensatory afforestation. No clearance without these. Simultaneously, explore alternatives — India has many coal blocks outside dense forests. The net present value (NPV) of forest land must be fully compensated.

Framework: Sustainable Development, Precautionary Principle, FRA 2006, Intergenerational Justice.

Case 27: The Lake Encroachment

Scenario: A 500-year-old city lake (a notified wetland) has been encroached by slum dwellers (1,000 families), luxury apartments (builder with political connections), and a garbage dump. As Municipal Commissioner, you have orders from the High Court to restore the lake within 6 months. The slum dwellers have nowhere to go. The builder has a stay from another court.

Ethical Issues: Wetland conservation vs housing rights, court orders, rule of law, political interference.

Stakeholders: Slum dwellers, builder, political patrons, city residents (flood control, water recharge), High Court.

Options: (a) Evict slums first as they are easiest to remove. (b) Demolish illegal builder structures first despite political pressure. (c) Develop a phased plan with slum rehabilitation and legal prosecution of builder. (d) Seek court clarification on conflicting orders.

Recommended Action: Option (c) — a comprehensive plan. Approach the High Court for a time-bound rehabilitation plan for slum dwellers under the PMAY (Urban) scheme. Simultaneously, proceed against the builder's illegal construction — the builder has violated environmental laws and CRZ norms. Lake restoration includes de-silting, sewage diversion and community participation.

Framework: Rule of Law, Rawls (protect the most vulnerable), Environmental Justice, Integrated planning.

Case 28: The Eco-Sensitive Zone

Scenario: The Ministry of Environment has proposed declaring 10 km around a national park as an Eco-Sensitive Zone (ESZ). Local villagers (50,000 people) protest — their houses, farms, and livelihoods fall within this zone and will face building restrictions. Hotels, resorts also oppose, claiming tourism will suffer. You are the local MP/MLA asked to take a stand.

Ethical Issues: Conservation vs local livelihoods, sustainable tourism, participatory planning.

Stakeholders: Villagers, hotel industry, forest department, wildlife, tourists, future generations.

Options: (a) Support the ESZ notification fully. (b) Oppose it as anti-people. (c) Negotiate for regulated zone with graded restrictions — inner core strict, outer core flexible. (d) Propose alternative livelihoods and compensation for affected families.

Recommended Action: Option (c) + (d). The Supreme Court has mandated ESZ for all protected areas. Argue for a graded approach: 0-1 km (no construction), 1-5 km (regulated eco-friendly construction), 5-10 km (normal with green clearance). Simultaneously advocate for a livelihood support package — eco-tourism training, organic farming premium, compensation for crop damage by wildlife.

Framework: Sustainable Development, Participatory Governance, Precautionary Principle, Environmental Justice.

7. Whistleblowing (4 Cases)

Case 29: The DDO's Discovery

Scenario: You are a Drawing and Disbursing Officer in a government department. You discover that the head of department has been claiming fake TA/DA for non-existent official tours — approximately Rs 15 lakh over 3 years. Other staff know but are silent. The department head is a senior IAS officer with political connections. You have just joined.

Ethical Issues: Whistleblowing vs career risk, professional integrity, bureaucratic collusion in corruption.

Stakeholders: You, department head, other staff, state government, taxpayers.

Options: (a) Keep quiet to protect your career. (b) Confront the department head directly. (c) Report to the Vigilance Department. (d) Collect all evidence and share with an RTI activist.

Recommended Action: Option (c). The Whistleblower Protection Act 2014 provides safeguards. Report through the proper channel — Chief Secretary and State Vigilance Commission with documentary evidence. Keep copies of all records in a safe place. Option (b) is risky — the officer may destroy evidence. Option (d) bypasses official channels which undermines institutional processes.

Framework: Whistleblower Protection Act, Deontology (duty to truth), Professional Integrity.

Case 30: The Medical Intern's Discovery

Scenario: As a medical intern in a government hospital, you discover that the hospital administration is buying expired surgical gloves and syringes from a supplier at 50% discount and using them on patients. The Medical Superintendent is involved. You reported to the Dean who asked you to mind your own business. Some patients have developed post-surgical infections.

Ethical Issues: Patient safety, medical ethics, whistleblowing retaliation, institutional corruption, danger to lives.

Stakeholders: Patients, interns, Medical Superintendent, Dean, supplier, hospital reputation.

Options: (a) Stay quiet — you are just an intern. (b) Collect evidence and report to the Medical Council and Health Minister. (c) Refuse to use expired material and encourage others. (d) Go to the media.

Recommended Action: Option (b). Patient lives are at stake — this is a criminal offence under the Drugs & Cosmetics Act. The Medical Council of India has a duty to act. Whistleblowing in healthcare is protected when done in public interest. Preserve physical samples. The post-surgical infections provide you with a strong evidence base.

Framework: Medical Ethics (First do no harm), Patient Safety, Public Health Ethics, Courage as a virtue.

Case 31: The Army Officer's Report

Scenario: As a mid-level Army officer, you discover that a defence procurement deal involves a kickback of Rs 50 crore through a middleman to senior officers. The equipment procured (night vision goggles) is substandard and could risk soldiers' lives. File is being pushed for final clearance and you have been asked to "not delay the process."

Ethical Issues: National security corruption, soldier safety, chain of command vs moral conscience.

Stakeholders: Soldiers, senior officers, middleman, defence manufacturer, your career, national security.

Options: (a) Follow orders and clear the file. (b) Note objections in writing and refuse to clear. (c) Report to the CBI through proper military channels. (d) Copy documents and approach a journalist.

Recommended Action: Option (b) + (c). Military discipline requires following the chain of command, but not when it involves illegality. Submit a detailed written objection through proper channels. If the system fails to act, approach the CBI through a retired officer contact or the Ministry of Defence's internal vigilance. Substandard equipment endangering soldiers is an unacceptable compromise.

Framework: Military ethics, Duty to nation, Whistleblowing (within chain), Utilitarianism (save soldiers' lives).

Case 32: The Bank Employee's Discovery

Scenario: As a mid-level manager in a public sector bank, you discover that the branch manager has been sanctioning large loans to shell companies controlled by a local politician. The loans (Rs 100 crore) are non-performing

assets now. The branch manager destroyed the original KYC documents. The politician is influential with the bank's chairman.

Ethical Issues: Banking fraud, corruption, document destruction, systemic failure, due diligence breach.

Stakeholders: Bank, depositors, branch manager, politician, chairman, you, shareholders (government).

Options: (a) Keep quiet — it's not your problem. (b) Report to the bank's vigilance department. (c) Report to CBI/CVC directly. (d) Copy all records and approach the RBI.

Recommended Action: Option (c) or (d). The fraud is too large for internal channels that may be compromised. The CVC (Central Vigilance Commission) has jurisdiction over PSB frauds above Rs 50 crore. The RBI's Integrated Ombudsman Scheme is another channel. Banks are in the business of public trust — every depositor's money is at stake.

Framework: Fiduciary duty, Rule of Law, Financial ethics, Whistleblower protection.

8. Gender Discrimination (4 Cases)

Case 33: The Pregnant Teacher

Scenario: A female government school teacher is denied maternity leave by the Block Education Officer (BEO) because she is a contractual employee (under Shiksha Mitra scheme). The BEO says contractual employees are not entitled to maternity benefits. The woman has worked for 4 years and is 6 months pregnant. You are the District Education Officer. The teacher appeals to you.

Ethical Issues: Gender discrimination, labour rights, contractual exploitation, maternity benefit rights.

Stakeholders: Teacher, unborn child, BEO, students, state education department.

Options: (a) Uphold BEO's decision — she is contractual. (b) Overrule BEO — Maternity Benefit Act 1961 applies to all women. (c) Compromise — give her 3 months unpaid leave. (d) Consult the law department.

Recommended Action: Option (b). The Maternity Benefit Act 1961 (amended 2017) applies to ALL establishments, including contract employees. The Supreme Court has held that denying maternity benefits to contract employees violates Article 14 and 15. Issue an order granting full 26 weeks paid maternity leave. Also, issue a general circular to all schools in the district clarifying the legal position.

Framework: Gender Justice, Article 14, 15, 42, Maternity Benefit Act, Human Rights.

Case 34: The Woman Sarpanch

Scenario: In a Gram Panchayat reserved for women (under 73rd Amendment), the elected woman Sarpanch is a proxy for her husband — she signs whatever he puts before her. The husband takes all decisions, handles all funds, and does all official dealings. The Panchayat Secretary is complicit. Women in the village feel this defeats the purpose of reservation.

Ethical Issues: Proxy sarpanch culture, 73rd Amendment violation, disempowerment, gender discrimination.

Stakeholders: Woman Sarpanch, husband, village women, Panchayat

Secretary, state Panchayati Raj department.

Options: (a) Do nothing — it's political reality. (b) Train the woman Sarpanch on her powers and duties. (c) Initiate disqualification proceedings against the husband for interfering. (d) Conduct awareness camps in the village on women's political rights.

Recommended Action: Option (b) + (d). The problem is lack of awareness and confidence. The District Panchayat Officer should conduct training for elected women representatives on their statutory powers. The 73rd Amendment's spirit is substantive representation, not just formal. Simultaneously, village-level awareness programmes for women. Option (c) may be considered if the husband's interference is proven beyond doubt.

Framework: 73rd Amendment, Gender Justice, Empowerment ethics, Ambedkar's vision of political equality.

Case 35: The Highway Project Manager

Scenario: You are a woman engineer posted as Project Manager of a highway construction project. The male-dominated workforce refuses to follow your instructions, delays meetings, and goes to the male Deputy Manager for approvals. Your male colleagues in other departments dismiss it as "women can't handle highway projects." Your boss (male) tells you to "be more accommodating."

Ethical Issues: Gender discrimination in workplace, hostile work environment, leadership undermined by bias.

Stakeholders: You, workforce, Deputy Manager, boss, project timeline, women in engineering.

Options: (a) Quit the project — it's affecting your mental health. (b) Assert your authority with disciplinary action. (c) Request the boss to issue a memo affirming your authority. (d) Build rapport with key workers while taking disciplinary action against insubordination.

Recommended Action: Option (d) — strategic combination. Issue a written order that all approvals must route through you. Use Sexual Harassment of Women at Workplace Act (POSH) if harassment crosses legal lines. Your competence as an engineer is your strongest asset — demonstrate it consistently. Document all instances of insubordination for HR action. The problem is structural, not personal.

Framework: Gender Justice, POSH Act, Virtue Ethics (resilience, competence), Right to dignified work.

Case 36: The Honour Killing Threat

Scenario: As District Magistrate, you receive an intelligence input that a Khap Panchayat has passed a death sentence on a young couple who married outside their caste. The couple has approached you for protection. The Khap leaders are influential and have threatened that if you provide police protection, they will ensure your transfer.

Ethical Issues: Right to life, caste discrimination, honour killing, state vs informal justice systems.

Stakeholders: Young couple, Khap leaders, police, your career, Supreme Court (Shakti Vahini judgment).

Options: (a) Provide police protection as per law. (b) Ask the family to mediate. (c) Arrest Khap leaders under preventive detention. (d) Advise the couple to leave the district.

Recommended Action: Option (a) + (c). The Supreme Court in Shakti Vahini v. Union of India (2018) has held that honour killings are not honour but barbaric murder. The state must protect couples. Immediate police protection, arrest of Khap leaders under relevant IPC sections, and witness protection. File compliance report to the High Court. Transfer threats are irrelevant — this is a matter of constitutional duty and human rights.

Framework: Right to Life (Article 21), Right to Choose Partner (Article 19/21), Supreme Court judgments, Human Rights.

9. Caste & Religion Discrimination (4 Cases)

Case 37: The Temple Entry Denied

Scenario: A group of Dalit families in your district want to enter a centuries-old temple that has traditionally barred Dalits. The temple trust refuses, citing tradition. The District Collector (you) has been asked by the High Court to ensure compliance with the Temple Entry Act and Article 25. The upper-caste community threatens violence if Dalits enter.

Ethical Issues: Religious discrimination, caste apartheid, Article 25 vs customary practice, law and order challenge.

Stakeholders: Dalit families, temple trust, upper-caste community, High Court, local police, state government.

Options: (a) Enforce entry with police protection. (b) Persuade the trust through dialogue and mediation. (c) Request the High Court for more time. (d) Organise a peace committee with community leaders.

Recommended Action: Option (d) + (a). First, convene a peace committee with all stakeholders. Explain the legal position — the Temple Entry Act and Article 25 guarantee entry to all Hindus, regardless of caste. If peace committee fails, enforce law with adequate police protection. The Constitution's vision of social justice requires active state intervention against caste discrimination.

Framework: Article 25, Temple Entry Act, Ambedkar's vision, Social Justice, Rule of Law.

Case 38: The Religious Conversion Camp

Scenario: An evangelical Christian group has set up a camp in a remote tribal area, offering free healthcare and education while conducting mass conversions. Locals complain the group uses "allurements" — free food, money, jobs. Anti-conversion activists threaten violence. The tribal community is divided. You are the District Magistrate.

Ethical Issues: Freedom of religion (Article 25) vs right against forced conversion, tribal vulnerability, communal harmony.

Stakeholders: Tribal community, evangelical group, anti-conversion activists, state government, you.

Options: (a) Ban the camp under the state's anti-conversion law. (b) Allow it — freedom of religion is constitutional. (c) Regulate — separate humanitarian work from religious activities. (d) Investigate if allurements are being used.

Recommended Action: Option (c) + (d). Article 25 protects the right to propagate, not the right to convert through force, fraud, or allurement. Ensure the humanitarian work (healthcare, education) continues without discrimination, but investigate allegations of allurement. The distinction between genuine faith and inducement is critical. Maintain communal harmony through community dialogue.

Framework: Article 25, Freedom of Conscience, Anti-conversion laws (state-specific), Communal Harmony.

Case 39: The Casteist Professor

Scenario: Your daughter, a first-generation Dalit student at a central university, complains that her professor (a senior Brahmin) has been making casteist remarks in class, grading SC/ST students unfairly, and refusing to guide their research. The university administration has received multiple complaints but done nothing. Your daughter is depressed and wants to drop out.

Ethical Issues: Caste discrimination in higher education, institutional failure, parental vs official role, SC/ST Atrocities Act.

Stakeholders: Your daughter, the professor, SC/ST students, university administration, you as official, your family.

Options: (a) Use your influence as a senior officer to have the professor transferred. (b) Advise your daughter to file a formal complaint under the PoA Act. (c) Write to the University Chancellor as a concerned parent. (d) Encourage all affected students to file a collective complaint.

Recommended Action: Option (b) + (d). The SC/ST (Prevention of Atrocities) Act provides for special courts and mandatory punishment for caste-based discrimination in educational institutions. A collective complaint from all affected students carries greater weight. Your official position should not be used — this must be resolved through legal-institutional channels, not personal influence.

Framework: Social Justice, SC/ST (PoA) Act, Rawls' Justice, Ambedkar's educational philosophy.

Case 40: The Interfaith Marriage

Scenario: A Hindu girl and Muslim boy have married under the Special Marriage Act. Both families threaten to kill them. The couple comes to you as SSP for protection. You have seen cases where even after police protection, couples were killed once protection was withdrawn. The girl's father is a local politician. The boy's family has disowned him.

Ethical Issues: Right to marry, honour killing threat, protection challenges, interfaith harmony.

Stakeholders: Couple, both families, politician father, police force, you.

Options: (a) Provide short-term police protection. (b) Arrange for the couple to relocate safely to another state. (c) Arrest the families under preventive detention if threats are credible. (d) Counsel the families to accept the marriage.

Recommended Action: Option (b) + (c). Under the Supreme Court's Shakti Vahini guidelines, the state must provide witness protection. Immediate arrest of those threatening violence under Section 151 CrPC. Arrange safe relocation to a shelter home in another district with identity protection. Long-term safety requires relocation. The Special Marriage Act was specifically designed to protect interfaith couples — its spirit must be upheld.

Framework: Article 21 (Right to Life), Special Marriage Act, Supreme Court's Shakti Vahini guidelines, Human Rights.

10. Disaster Response (4 Cases)

Case 41: The Flash Floods

Scenario: Sudden flash floods have marooned 50 villages in your district. Rescue operations are ongoing but slow. A political leader arrives with a TV crew and demands that rescue boats be focused on his constituency (40% of boats diverted). Other villages complain of discrimination. The Chief Minister's office calls and asks you to "facilitate the leader's expectations."

Ethical Issues: Political interference in disaster management, equitable relief distribution, media manipulation.

Stakeholders: Affected villagers, political leader, TV crew, CM's office, NDRF, you.

Options: (a) Divert boats as asked. (b) Refuse — explain that rescue is based on need and severity, not politics. (c) Create a transparent rescue priority list based on water depth and population. (d) Request the NDRF commander to handle the politician.

Recommended Action: Option (b) + (c). The Disaster Management Act 2005 mandates need-based, non-discriminatory relief. Establish a transparent control room with real-time information. Invite the politician to participate in rescue coordination rather than divert resources. Document all requests for departmental records. The NDMA guidelines clearly prohibit political discrimination in disaster relief.

Framework: Disaster Management Act, Humanitarian ethics, Equity, Right to Life, Good Governance.

Case 42: The Pandemic Response

Scenario: During a pandemic, your district receives only 5,000 vaccine doses against a requirement of 50,000. There are reports that private hospitals are vaccinating those who can pay while poor and elderly wait. A vaccine manufacturer offers 10,000 extra doses to the district if you "expedite" clearance for their new plant (pending with pollution board).

Ethical Issues: Vaccine equity, exploitation of crisis, bribery in disguise, preferential treatment of private sector.

Stakeholders: Poor and elderly, private hospitals, manufacturer, pollution

board, you.

Options: (a) Accept the offer — more vaccines save more lives. (b) Reject the offer — it's unethical to use crisis for clearance. (c) Accept but ensure equitable distribution. (d) Report the manufacturer to the drug controller.

Recommended Action: Option (b) + (d). Accepting the offer creates a dangerous precedent — it rewards manipulation during a crisis and undermines the regulatory process. Prioritise vaccine allocation for the most vulnerable as per government guidelines. Crack down on private hospitals violating allocation norms. Report the manufacturer's attempt to the appropriate authority.

Framework: Distributive Justice, Public Health Ethics, Transparency, Rule of Law.

Case 43: The Industrial Accident

Scenario: A chemical factory in your district has a gas leak at 2 AM. 50 people have died, 200 hospitalised. The factory owner, a politically connected industrialist, asks you to blame "sabotage by anti-national elements" rather than safety violations. He offers Rs 10 crore for the district's relief fund if you cooperate. The actual cause appears to be negligence — safety valves were bypassed to cut costs.

Ethical Issues: Cover-up of corporate crime, truth vs political pressure, compensation for victims, public safety.

Stakeholders: Victims & families, factory owner, political connections, government, you.

Options: (a) Accept the narrative and the money. (b) Order a thorough investigation by the Factories Inspectorate. (c) Register an FIR under IPC and Environment Protection Act. (d) Accept the money but order an investigation secretly.

Recommended Action: Option (b) + (c). The truth must be investigated without fear or favour. The Factories Act and Environment Protection Act require mandatory investigation of industrial accidents. The ₹10 crore offer does not absolve criminal liability. Ensure immediate compensation to families from the owner's assets (attached by court if necessary). The cover-up narrative is itself a criminal conspiracy.

Framework: Corporate Ethics, Rule of Law, Polluter Pays Principle, Right to Life, Public Safety.

Case 44: The Earthquake Relief

Scenario: A major earthquake has hit your state. International aid agencies offer assistance. The central government initially refuses foreign aid citing "self-sufficiency." However, local relief efforts are overwhelmed. Thousands are homeless, winter is approaching, and relief camps lack supplies. You are the Divisional Commissioner. The state government asks you to manage without foreign aid.

Ethical Issues: National pride vs humanitarian need, political ideology vs saving lives.

Stakeholders: Earthquake victims, international agencies, central and state government, relief workers, you.

Options: (a) Follow the government's directive. (b) Publicly advocate for accepting foreign aid. (c) Accept aid discreetly through NGOs and Red Cross. (d) Use disaster management funds to contract international expertise as "consultants."

Recommended Action: Option (c) — accept aid through humanitarian channels. The UN's Humanitarian Principles prioritise saving lives over political considerations. Coordinate with Indian Red Cross Society and international NGOs to channel aid. The National Disaster Management Plan allows for international assistance coordination through the UN. The ethical imperative is to save lives — self-sufficiency is irrelevant when lives are at stake.

Framework: Humanitarian ethics, Utilitarianism (save maximum lives), Disaster Management Act, International cooperation.

11. Technology Ethics (3 Cases)

Case 45: The Facial Recognition System

Scenario: Your state police have installed facial recognition cameras across the city with 90% accuracy. The system flagged 500 "matches" for wanted criminals — but 50 were false positives (wrongly identified innocent citizens). One false positive — a woman — was publicly detained and harassed before being released. Civil liberties groups protest the system's deployment without legal framework.

Ethical Issues: Privacy vs security, algorithmic bias, false positives harming innocents, surveillance state concerns.

Stakeholders: Citizens, falsely accused woman, police, civil liberties groups, technology provider.

Options: (a) Continue deployment — 90% accuracy is acceptable for crime prevention. (b) Suspend the system until accuracy improves and legal framework is created. (c) Continue use but with human verification of all matches. (d) Deploy only in high-crime areas with court oversight.

Recommended Action: Option (b) + (c). The Supreme Court's Puttaswamy judgment (Right to Privacy) requires any surveillance system to have a legal framework, proportionality, and oversight. The false positive rate (10%) is unacceptably high when it leads to public harassment. A data protection framework and independent oversight mechanism must precede deployment. Human verification is the minimum safeguard during trial.

Framework: Right to Privacy (Puttaswamy), Data Protection, AI Ethics, Proportionality, Human Rights.

Case 46: The Social Media Misinformation

Scenario: Your district has seen 10 mob lynching incidents in the past year triggered by fake news on WhatsApp. The latest victim is a Muslim truck driver falsely accused of child lifting. You can impose Section 144 and temporarily ban internet. But this affects 1 million legitimate users — students, businesses, daily wage workers dependent on digital payments. The Home Ministry advises blocking.

Ethical Issues: Public safety vs digital rights, censorship, misinformation control, disproportionate impact.

Stakeholders: Potential victims, 1M internet users, WhatsApp, state government, police, you.

Options: (a) Ban internet temporarily — lives are at stake. (b) Don't ban — it infringes fundamental rights. (c) Targeted blocking of specific groups/areas with proactive community policing. (d) Work with WhatsApp and local leaders on verified information channels.

Recommended Action: Option (c) + (d). Blanket internet ban violates Article 19(1)(a) and Puttaswamy. Instead, deploy community policing — identify and prosecute original spreaders of fake news under IPC 153A and IT Act 66D. Work with WhatsApp to enable fact-checking features. Establish a district-level rapid response team to counter misinformation. Empower local leaders (religious, caste) as verified information nodes.

Framework: Article 19, Proportionality, Public Safety, Community Policing, IT Act.

Case 47: The AI in Healthcare

Scenario: A private AI diagnostic tool used in your district hospital (donated by a corporate foundation) misdiagnosed 5 cases of tuberculosis as pneumonia, leading to treatment delays and 2 deaths. The tool was approved by the central government on a fast-track basis during the pandemic. You discover the AI was trained on non-Indian population data. The hospital wants to continue using it for "resource-constrained settings."

Ethical Issues: AI safety, regulatory gaps, data bias (non-Indian training), corporate interests vs patient safety.

Stakeholders: Patients, hospital, corporate foundation, central government, doctors, you.

Options: (a) Suspend use until accuracy on Indian population is validated. (b) Continue use with mandatory doctor verification of all AI diagnoses. (c) Report to the central drug controller for regulatory action. (d) Commission an independent audit of the tool's accuracy.

Recommended Action: Option (a) + (d). The AI is a medical device under the Drugs & Cosmetics Act rules (2020 notification). Suspend its use pending independent validation. The ethical principle of "first do no harm" applies to AI tools as much as human doctors. The bias from non-Indian training data is a well-documented AI ethics problem. Report to the Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation.

Framework: Medical Ethics (non-maleficence), AI Ethics (fairness, accountability), Regulatory compliance, Patient safety.

12. Media Ethics (3 Cases)

Case 48: The Paid News Allegation

Scenario: A local newspaper has published highly favourable articles about a mining company that is seeking environmental clearance for a project in your district. Your intelligence suggests the paper was paid Rs 25 lakh for these articles (paid news). The company is accused of violating environmental norms. The newspaper editor is the brother of the minister overseeing the clearance.

Ethical Issues: Paid news, conflict of interest, environmental violation cover-up, media corruption.

Stakeholders: Public (readers), mining company, newspaper editor, minister, environment, you.

Options: (a) Ignore — it's a media matter. (b) Report to the Press Council of India with evidence. (c) Ensure the environmental clearance process is rigorous and transparent. (d) Leak the payment details to another media outlet.

Recommended Action: Option (b) + (c). The Press Council of India has declared paid news as an unethical practice. Submit evidence to the PCI with a formal complaint. Simultaneously, ensure the environmental clearance follows due process — public hearing, expert committee evaluation, and compliance with EC norms. The two actions together address both the media corruption and the environmental risk.

Framework: Media Ethics, Press Council guidelines, Environmental justice, Transparency, Good Governance.

Case 49: The Sting Operation

Scenario: A TV news channel approaches you with a sting operation that shows a prominent opposition leader accepting a bribe. The channel wants you to arrest the leader immediately — before elections next week. The footage appears genuine but may be selectively edited. The channel's owner has close ties with the ruling party. The leader claims it's a political conspiracy. You have 24 hours before the channel airs the story.

Ethical Issues: Media trial, selective sting, political manipulation of law enforcement, electoral integrity.

Stakeholders: Opposition leader, TV channel, ruling party, voters, police, you.

Options: (a) Arrest the leader based on the footage. (b) Request the channel to share full unedited footage for forensic analysis. (c) Register an FIR but no arrest until investigation. (d) Report the matter to the Election Commission as potential electoral malpractice.

Recommended Action: Option (c) + (d). Register a preliminary inquiry. The Supreme Court has held that media cannot conduct a trial. The unedited footage must be examined by forensic experts. The Election Commission must be informed of any potential electoral malpractice. Your duty is to the truth and the law, not to a news channel's editorial agenda. Option (b) is essential — without the full footage, no action can be based on selective editing.

Framework: Media Ethics, Natural Justice, Rule of Law, Neutrality of civil service, Electoral integrity.

Case 50: The Anonymous Source

Scenario: An investigative journalist approaches you with documents proving that a large pharmaceutical company sold adulterated medicines during the pandemic, leading to 20 deaths. The journalist refuses to reveal her source (a company insider). She wants you to arrest the company's directors. The documents are convincing but would be inadmissible in court without the source's testimony.

Ethical Issues: Whistleblower identity protection, journalist-source confidentiality, evidence admissibility, public health.

Stakeholders: Journalist, source, victims & families, pharmaceutical company, public health, you.

Options: (a) Arrest directors based on documents alone. (b) Tell journalist that source must testify for conviction. (c) Register FIR and investigate independently to gather admissible evidence. (d) Pressure the journalist to reveal the source.

Recommended Action: Option (c). Register an FIR under the Drugs & Cosmetics Act and IPC for culpable homicide. Use the documents as starting points for an independent investigation — seize company records, interview former employees, sample medicines. The journalist's source confidentiality is protected under journalistic ethics and Article 19(1)(a). Conviction requires legally admissible evidence gathered by the state — the journalist's documents are leads, not proof.

Framework: Public Health Ethics, Media Ethics (source protection), Rule of Law, Criminal justice procedure.

Master Strategy for Ethics Case Studies: Practice the 6-step framework daily. In the exam, spend 5 minutes identifying issues and stakeholders, 5 minutes evaluating options, and 5 minutes writing the recommended action with justification. Every answer must show: (a) awareness of rules and laws, (b) empathy for stakeholders, (c) clear ethical reasoning, and (d) practical implementation sense.

Distribution Strategy: The 50 cases cover all major themes. In the exam, 5-6 cases appear from which you choose 4-5. Your preparation must cover at least 2 from each theme to handle any combination. Focus especially on bribery, conflict of interest, personal vs professional duty, and environment cases — these appear most frequently.

Common Mistake: Many students write "I will talk to them and convince them" as the recommended action. This is vague. A good answer must specify: talk to whom, when, how, what legal provisions apply, what administrative orders will be issued, and within what timeframe. Specificity in action plans distinguishes top scorers.

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All case studies based on ethical reasoning frameworks as prescribed in the UPSC GS4 syllabus. Practice applying the framework to new case types for best results.